

KRISHNA MURARI KUSHAN



Minister Sushil Kumar Modi.

But like all men in a hurry, Nitish too is beset with problems—some of his own making. Although his social surgery has won him new friends, those who had earlier stood by him, have not much love left for him. During his tours, Nitish is checking primary health centres, examining PDS shops and personally asking labourers if they are being paid the minimum wages. The timing of his empirical scrutiny, however, makes it more than just administrative. Feeding his resolve with stubborn discipline, when it comes to walking the

once supported him against Lalu Prasad—are leading the charge to pull him down. Many who had left others—like former minister Naagmani—to join Nitish then, have now switched sides and are working overtime against him. If these leaders take away even a fraction of their support base away from Nitish, they can deal a body blow to his plans of returning to power.

But, why have so many friends deserted him? Is it because success always comes at a price? Or is it because they find Nitish acting pricey? It seems a bit of both. All who left him have blamed Nitish for being an “autocrat who makes everyone toe his line”. “He allows not the slightest deviation from what he wants. He discourages discussions even during cabinet meet-

NITISH IS LOOKING AT THE COMING ELECTIONS AS A REFERENDUM ON HIS RULE

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Clean track record, delivered better governance than predecessors, has an acceptable face with across-the-board support base.	No second in command, autocratic, arrogant, guided by a coterie of anti-Lalu people, regional disparities neutralise the development card.	Opposition yet to get its act together as the Congress is still a house divided and Lalu-Paswan being almost a spent force.	Associates trying to clip vote bank, upper castes disenchanted, compulsion to contest with the BJP might neutralise minority support.

years: the weekly Janata Darbar when the doors of the house/office were flung open for commoners to bring their problems to him directly for redressal. He has since embarked on a statewide tour that will see him touch all the 38 districts to reach out to those who did not or could not reach him during all those Mondays. Is Nitish getting just a little edgy before the elections, now that he has a crown to defend? Does he think his goodwill is just not good enough? Perhaps the engineer-turned-politician is desperate to wrest the crucial advantage of making the first move. “Nitish Kumar is a man with a sharp memory who works for 15-16 hours. He has also been a finisher, taking ideas to execution,” says Deputy Chief

extra mile, Nitish is already what his political adversaries, including the RJD chief, are struggling to become. And to cap it all, he has always been perfectly composed, exceedingly articulate and dangerously diplomatic. Yet, everything is not hunky-dory for Nitish in the run-up to the polls.

Then, Nitish was wholeheartedly backed against Lalu's juggernaut. That was a time when friends of all hues and with all views from the social and political worlds—besides voters from upper castes to Extremely Backward Castes (EBCs), from traders to professionals and from housewives to students—backed him to the hilt. Now, many of his friends—like Munger MP Rajiv Ranjan Singh “Lallan” and former MP Prabhunath Singh—who

ings,” says Naagmani. Last year, BJP MP Bhola Singh—who had once criticised Nitish at an NDA legislative meeting at the chief minister's official residence in Patna—could not meet him despite seeking an appointment.

The Nitish Government's biggest achievement has been controlling crime, although it has fallen short of expectations. Over 44,000 criminals convicted since 2006 is nonetheless an impressive tally. Over 356 people, mostly government officials, have also been arrested for taking bribes. The economy has grown by 11.35 per cent and 2,417 km of roads were paved during the last fiscal alone. Nitish has even shown zero tolerance against nepotism that is considered one of the biggest reasons for the decline of Lalu